

JOURNAL OF EDUCATIONAL MANAGEMENT AND SUPERVISION (JEMAS)



Published in the Department of Educational Administration and Planning,
Joseph Sarwuan Tarka University, Makurdi

Stakeholders' Involvement in the Management of Secondary Schools: Implications for Teachers' Effectiveness and Cooperative Governance in Cross River State, Nigeria

Ategwu, Patrick Ogar

Department of Education Foundations

School of Education

Saint Augustine University of Tanzania

patrickategwu@gmail.com

Abstract

This study examined stakeholders' involvement in the management of secondary schools and its relationship with teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance in Cross River State, Nigeria. The study was motivated by concerns regarding ineffective school governance, inadequate stakeholder participation, and persistent challenges affecting teacher performance in public secondary schools. The study adopted a convergent parallel mixed-methods design, integrating quantitative and qualitative approaches. The population comprised approximately 6,000 teachers, principals, Parent-Teacher Association (PTA) representatives, and community leaders drawn from 428 public secondary schools in Cross River State. A stratified random sampling technique was used to select 240 respondents, while 24 participants were purposively selected for interviews. Data were collected using the Stakeholders' Involvement and School Management Questionnaire (SISMQ), the Teachers' Effectiveness and Cooperative Governance Scale (TECGS), and semi-structured interview guides. The instruments yielded Cronbach's Alpha reliability coefficients of 0.86 and 0.83, respectively. Quantitative data were analysed using frequencies, percentages, and Pearson Product Moment Correlation Coefficient (PPMC), while qualitative data were analysed thematically. The findings revealed strong positive and statistically significant relationships between stakeholders' involvement and teachers' effectiveness ($r = 0.78, p < 0.05$), as well as between stakeholders' involvement and cooperative governance ($r = 0.82, p < 0.05$). Qualitative findings further indicated that stakeholder participation was associated with improved teacher accountability, enhanced resource mobilisation, greater transparency, and stronger collaborative decision-making processes. The study concludes that stakeholder involvement is positively

associated with teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance in secondary schools in Cross River State. However, given the cross-sectional nature of the study, the findings should be interpreted as demonstrating relationships rather than causal effects. The study recommends the institutionalisation of stakeholder participation frameworks, strengthening of School-Based Management Committees, and capacity-building programmes for school administrators and stakeholders to enhance participatory governance in secondary schools.

Keywords: Stakeholders' Involvement, Secondary School Management, Teachers' Effectiveness, Cooperative Governance and Participatory Governance

Introduction

The management of secondary schools in Nigeria has increasingly been recognised as a multidimensional enterprise that extends beyond formal school administration to encompass the active participation of a wide range of stakeholders, including parents, community members, civil society organisations, alumni associations, religious bodies, and the private sector (Nwankwo, 2020). In Cross River State, as in many other Nigerian states, the governance of public secondary schools has historically been dominated by government bureaucracies, with minimal structured input from non-governmental stakeholders. This centralised approach to school management has been criticised for fostering inefficiency, reducing accountability, and limiting the responsiveness of schools to the educational needs and social realities of their communities (Bassey & Okon, 2022). According to Ategwu et al. (2023), major challenges affecting the management of secondary schools include inadequate administrative competence, emotional instability among school leaders, misplacement of priorities, and poor systemic coordination. Consequently, the role of school managers remains crucial in shaping the future of schools, teachers, and students. For schools to be effectively managed, administrators and their subordinates must embrace inclusivity, ensure prudent utilisation of resources, and promote effective governance practices. The growing recognition of stakeholders' involvement as a viable strategy for addressing the challenges confronting secondary school management has therefore attracted considerable scholarly and policy attention in Nigeria and across sub-Saharan Africa (Adeyemi, 2021).

Stakeholders' involvement in school management refers to the systematic and meaningful participation of all individuals, groups, and organisations with a legitimate interest in the educational outcomes of a school in the processes of planning, decision-making, resource mobilisation, implementation, and evaluation of school programmes and policies (Fullan, 2020). In the context of secondary education in Cross River State, stakeholders encompass a diverse constituency including parents and guardians, Parent-Teacher Associations (PTAs), community leaders, traditional rulers, local government authorities, non-governmental organisations, religious bodies, alumni associations, and the private sector. Each of these stakeholder groups brings unique resources, perspectives, and forms of accountability to the governance of secondary schools, and their collective involvement has the potential to transform school management from a closed

bureaucratic process into an open, democratic, and community-responsive system (UNESCO, 2022).

Teachers' effectiveness refers to the capacity of teachers to plan, deliver, and evaluate instruction in ways that maximise student learning outcomes, foster classroom engagement, and contribute to the broader educational goals of the school (Stronge, 2018). Research evidence consistently demonstrates that teachers' effectiveness is not merely a product of individual professional competence but is also significantly influenced by the organisational environment within which teachers operate. Ndem et al. (2023) argue that teacher effectiveness extends beyond classroom instruction to include community service, professional commitment, and adherence to institutional norms and values. Nevertheless, teacher ineffectiveness is often linked to inadequate opportunities for professional development and retraining. In a rapidly evolving society driven by technological advancement, teachers who are not continuously updated may struggle to adapt to emerging educational realities and innovations. Schools characterised by strong stakeholder involvement are more likely to provide teachers with adequate resources, professional support, community recognition, and clearly defined institutional goals, all of which contribute to enhanced teacher effectiveness (Obasi & Nwosu, 2022). In Cross River State, where many secondary school teachers operate under conditions of resource constraints, low motivation, and weak institutional support, stakeholder involvement presents a promising mechanism for improving the conditions necessary for effective teaching and learning.

Cooperative governance is a model of school management in which decision-making authority, accountability, and responsibility for educational outcomes are shared among multiple stakeholders, including school administrators, teachers, parents, community members, and government agencies through structured, transparent, and participatory processes (Ncube & Jerie, 2021). Cooperative governance contrasts with the top-down administrative models that have traditionally characterised secondary school management in Nigeria and aligns with the broader principles of democratic governance, community ownership, and shared accountability that underpin contemporary educational reforms across Africa (Oduya & Odey, 2023). In Cross River State, the promotion of cooperative governance in secondary schools is particularly important given documented cases of financial mismanagement, teacher absenteeism, infrastructural deterioration, and policy non-compliance that have undermined educational quality in the state (Eteng & Ogbaji, 2022).

Literature Review

Conceptual Framework

Stakeholders' involvement in school management is conceptualised in this study as a multi-dimensional construct encompassing four primary dimensions: community participation in school governance, parental engagement in educational planning and monitoring, alumni and private sector contributions to school development, and civil society oversight of institutional accountability. Each of these dimensions interacts with and reinforces the others to create a comprehensive stakeholder ecosystem that shapes the management culture and governance quality

of secondary schools (Fullan, 2020). Community participation involves the active engagement of local community members, traditional leaders, and local government representatives in school decision-making, resource provision, and environmental safety. Parental engagement encompasses the involvement of parents and guardians in monitoring teacher attendance, supporting homework and learning at home, participating in PTA governance, and contributing to school development plans. Alumni and private sector contributions involve the mobilisation of former students and corporate entities to provide financial resources, mentorship, infrastructure support, and professional development for school staff. Civil society oversight refers to the role of non-governmental organisations, religious bodies, and civic groups in monitoring school governance, promoting transparency, and advocating for educational rights.

Teachers' effectiveness, as conceptualised in this study, encompasses five key dimensions: quality of lesson preparation and planning, effectiveness of classroom instructional delivery, thoroughness of student assessment and feedback, professional collaboration with colleagues, and contribution to school development and governance (Stronge, 2018). These dimensions collectively constitute a comprehensive portrait of teacher performance that goes beyond the narrow focus on examination results to encompass the full range of professional responsibilities that define an effective teacher. Cooperative governance is conceptualised as an institutional arrangement in which multiple stakeholders share authority, responsibility, and accountability for school management outcomes through structured participatory processes including school-based management committees, PTAs, open budget meetings, community reporting, and collaborative school development planning (Ncube & Jerie, 2021).

Theoretical Framework

This study is grounded in two complementary theoretical frameworks: the Stakeholder Theory, as articulated by Freeman (1984), and the Participatory Democracy Theory, as developed by Dewey (1916) and later extended by Habermas (1984). Freeman's Stakeholder Theory argues that the effective governance of any organisation including educational institutions requires the identification, engagement, and balancing of the interests of all groups with a stake in the organisation's activities and outcomes. Applied to secondary school management, this theory implies that school administrators who engage diverse stakeholders in governance processes will achieve superior organisational outcomes, including higher teacher effectiveness, improved resource mobilisation, and stronger institutional accountability (Freeman, 1984). In the context of Cross River State secondary schools, this theoretical lens helps to explain how the systematic involvement of parents, community members, and other stakeholders in school governance can transform managerial outcomes and enhance the professional environment within which teachers operate.

Dewey's Participatory Democracy Theory and its Habermasian extension through communicative action theory provide a complementary perspective by arguing that genuine democracy requires the active and equal participation of all affected parties in the processes of collective decision-making (Habermas, 1984). Applied to school governance, this theoretical framework suggests that

cooperative governance characterised by structured participation, open deliberation, and shared accountability is not merely a managerial strategy but a democratic imperative that enhances institutional legitimacy, promotes community ownership, and sustains the commitment of all stakeholders, including teachers, to the educational mission of the school. Together, these two theoretical frameworks provide a robust conceptual foundation for examining how stakeholders' involvement in secondary school management produces the twin outcomes of teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance in Cross River State.

Empirical Literature

In the United States, Epstein (2018) conducted an extensive longitudinal study on school-family-community partnerships and their effects on teacher effectiveness and school governance quality in public secondary schools. The study demonstrated that schools with institutionalised stakeholder involvement structures reported higher teacher morale, greater classroom engagement, improved student achievement, and more transparent governance processes compared to schools with minimal stakeholder participation. Epstein (2018) identified six typologies of parental and community involvement parenting, communicating, volunteering, learning at home, decision-making, and collaborating with community and showed that each typology contributes distinctively to improving the professional environment of teachers and the governance culture of schools. These findings established a strong empirical foundation for the thesis that stakeholder involvement serves as a panacea for teacher effectiveness and cooperative governance.

In Finland, Sahlberg (2021) studied the role of community and parental involvement in the governance of comprehensive schools and found that the distributed leadership model, which integrates teachers, parents, and community representatives into school governance structures, was a key factor in Finland's consistently high international education rankings. Sahlberg's analysis demonstrated that teacher effectiveness in Finland is partly attributable to the professional trust and community support generated by robust stakeholder involvement in school management, which provides teachers with the social capital, resource base, and institutional legitimacy necessary to perform at high levels. This international evidence from a high-performing education system reinforces the central argument of the current study by demonstrating that stakeholder involvement is a structural determinant of teacher effectiveness and institutional governance quality.

In South Africa, Mestry (2017) investigated the role of School Governing Bodies (SGBs) South Africa's primary institutional mechanism for stakeholder involvement in school management in promoting teacher effectiveness and democratic governance in public secondary schools. The study found that schools with active and capacitated SGBs demonstrated significantly higher levels of teacher professional development, resource utilisation efficiency, financial accountability, and community trust compared to schools with dysfunctional governing bodies. Mestry (2017) concluded that stakeholder involvement through SGBs represents one of South Africa's most important tools for improving educational governance and teacher performance, particularly in historically disadvantaged schools. These findings from a comparable African context provide

strong empirical support for the argument advanced in the current study regarding the potential of stakeholder involvement to transform secondary school management in Cross River State.

In Ghana, Akyeampong (2020) examined community participation in school management and its effects on teacher attendance, instructional quality, and school accountability in public secondary schools in rural districts. The study found that communities with strong traditions of school oversight including regular community visits to schools, participation in School Performance Appraisal Meetings, and community-led teacher accountability mechanisms had significantly lower teacher absenteeism rates, higher lesson completion rates, and better examination results compared to communities with weak participation cultures. These findings from West Africa, in a context that shares many similarities with Cross River State in terms of governance structures and resource challenges, strongly suggest that community stakeholder involvement can be a powerful lever for improving teacher effectiveness and cooperative governance in Nigerian secondary schools.

In Kenya, Okoth (2021) studied the influence of Board of Management (BOM) involvement on teachers' professional performance in public secondary schools. The findings demonstrated that schools with actively engaged BOMs, which in Kenya include parents, community members, and local government representatives, consistently reported higher teacher attendance, more systematic lesson delivery, and better student academic outcomes compared to schools with passive or dysfunctional governance boards. Okoth (2021) emphasised that stakeholder involvement through the BOM created a culture of mutual accountability between the school and its community, which in turn motivated teachers to maintain higher professional standards. The East African evidence from Kenya thus aligns closely with the theoretical predictions of both Freeman's Stakeholder Theory and Dewey's Participatory Democracy Theory, and provides direct empirical relevance for the current study in Cross River State.

In Uganda, Ssekamwa and Lugumba (2020) conducted a qualitative study on the role of parent and community participation in enhancing cooperative governance in government secondary schools. Their findings revealed that schools with structured community-school partnership frameworks, which included regular open-day governance meetings, community financial oversight committees, and teacher performance feedback mechanisms, demonstrated more transparent financial management, lower incidence of governance conflicts, and higher levels of teacher job satisfaction and professional commitment. These outcomes were attributed to the trust-building function of stakeholder involvement, which aligned the interests of teachers, administrators, and community members around shared educational goals and created a collective sense of responsibility for school outcomes.

In Nigeria, Nwankwo (2020) investigated the relationship between parent-teacher association activities and teachers' job performance in secondary schools in Anambra State. The study found a significant positive correlation between the level of PTA engagement in school management including resource provision, policy advocacy, teacher welfare support, and classroom environment improvement and teachers' lesson preparation quality, punctuality, and instructional delivery. Nwankwo (2020) recommended the strengthening of PTAs as governance institutions

rather than mere fundraising bodies, arguing that their full integration into school management decision-making processes would yield substantial dividends for teacher effectiveness and institutional governance. This Nigerian evidence from a comparable South-East context provides direct empirical support for the current study in Cross River State.

In Cross River State specifically, Bassey and Okon (2022) documented that stakeholder involvement in secondary school management had remained largely tokenistic, with PTAs, community leaders, and alumni associations being consulted primarily for fundraising purposes rather than integrated into genuine governance processes. Their study revealed that this limited stakeholder participation was associated with weak institutional accountability, persistent teacher absenteeism, and inadequate resource management in Cross River State secondary schools. The study called for a paradigm shift in stakeholder engagement that would transform passive donors into active governance partners, thereby harnessing the full potential of stakeholder involvement to address the governance deficits and teacher effectiveness challenges confronting secondary schools in the state. Eteng and Ogbaji (2022) similarly found that schools in Cross River State that had piloted community-based school management committees reported significant improvements in teacher punctuality, parent satisfaction, and resource accountability, suggesting that the panacea function of stakeholder involvement is realisable within the specific governance context of Cross River State.

Methodology

This study adopted a mixed-method research approach, integrating quantitative and qualitative methodologies to achieve a comprehensive understanding of stakeholders' involvement in secondary school management and its influence on teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance in Cross River State, Nigeria. The mixed-method approach was considered appropriate because it facilitates the triangulation of numerical and narrative data, thereby enhancing the depth, breadth, and credibility of research findings (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2018). Specifically, a convergent parallel mixed-methods design was employed, whereby quantitative and qualitative data were collected concurrently, analysed separately, and subsequently integrated during interpretation. This design enabled the researcher to validate quantitative findings with rich qualitative insights obtained from teachers, principals, PTA representatives, and community leaders.

The study population comprised all teachers, principals, PTA representatives, and community leaders associated with the 428 public secondary schools in Cross River State. According to records from the Cross River State Ministry of Education (2024), the target population was estimated at approximately 6,000 individuals. A stratified random sampling technique was used to select 240 respondents from the three educational zones of Calabar, Ogoja, and Ikom. The sample consisted of 120 teachers, 24 principals, 48 PTA representatives, and 48 community leaders. Stratification ensured adequate representation of both geographical locations and stakeholder categories. In addition, twenty-four secondary schools were selected through simple random sampling across the three educational zones.

Data were collected using two researcher-developed instruments. The Stakeholders' Involvement and School Management Questionnaire (SISMQ) measured respondents' perceptions regarding the nature, frequency, and quality of stakeholder participation in school management across four dimensions: community participation, parental involvement, alumni and private-sector contributions, and civil society oversight. The Teachers' Effectiveness and Cooperative Governance Scale (TECGS) assessed perceptions of teachers' professional effectiveness and the extent of cooperative governance practices within schools. Both instruments were structured on a five-point Likert scale ranging from Strongly Agree (5) to Strongly Disagree (1). Qualitative data were obtained through semi-structured interviews conducted with 24 purposively selected participants, comprising six respondents from each stakeholder category, to gain deeper insights into experiences and perceptions of stakeholder involvement in school management.

The content validity of the instruments was established through expert review by three specialists in Educational Management from the University of Calabar, while face validity was confirmed by two experienced secondary school principals. A pilot study involving 30 respondents from schools outside the study sample yielded Cronbach's Alpha reliability coefficients of 0.86 for the SISMQ and 0.83 for the TECGS, indicating satisfactory internal consistency and reliability of the instruments.

The study was guided by the following null hypothesis:

1. There is no significant relationship between stakeholders' involvement in secondary school management and teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance in public secondary schools in Cross River State.

Quantitative data were analysed using frequencies, percentages, and Pearson Product Moment Correlation Coefficient (PPMC) with the aid of Statistical Package for the Social Sciences (SPSS) Version 26. The PPMC was employed to determine the strength and direction of the relationship between stakeholders' involvement and the dependent variables of teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance. All hypotheses were tested at the 0.05 level of significance. Qualitative data were analysed using thematic analysis through an inductive coding procedure that enabled the identification, organisation, and interpretation of recurring patterns and themes. The emergent themes were used to corroborate, explain, and enrich the quantitative findings.

Test of Hypothesis

1. There is no significant relationship between stakeholders' involvement in secondary school management and teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance in public secondary schools in Cross River State.

Table 1: *Pearson Product Moment Correlation Analysis of Stakeholders' Involvement, Teachers' Effectiveness, and Cooperative Governance (N = 240)*

Variables	N	r	p-value	Decision
Stakeholders' Involvement and Teachers' Effectiveness	240	0.78	0.000	Reject H ₀

Stakeholders' Involvement and Cooperative Governance	240	0.82	0.000	Reject H_0
--	-----	------	-------	--------------

Source: Field Data (2026)

The results in Table 3 indicate a strong positive and statistically significant relationship between stakeholders' involvement and teachers' effectiveness ($r = 0.78$, $p < 0.05$). Similarly, a strong positive and statistically significant relationship was found between stakeholders' involvement and cooperative governance ($r = 0.82$, $p < 0.05$). Since the p-values are less than the 0.05 level of significance, the null hypothesis was rejected. The findings suggest that schools with higher levels of stakeholder involvement tend to report higher levels of teachers' effectiveness and stronger cooperative governance practices.

Findings and Discussion

This section presents the findings in relation to the single objective of the study: to determine the extent to which stakeholders' involvement in the management of secondary schools serves as a panacea for teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance in Cross River State. The findings are presented in two thematic clusters stakeholders' involvement and teachers' effectiveness (Table 1), and stakeholders' involvement and cooperative governance (Table 2) followed by integrated discussion that draws on both quantitative and qualitative evidence.

Stakeholders' Involvement and Teachers' Effectiveness

Table 2 presents respondents' perceptions of the influence of stakeholders' involvement in school management on teachers' effectiveness in secondary schools in Cross River State.

Table 2: Respondents' Responses on Stakeholders' Involvement and Teachers' Effectiveness in Secondary Schools in Cross River State (N = 240)

Items	Response Options F (%)				
	SD	D	N	A	SA
Community participation in school governance enhances teachers' professional accountability and lesson delivery quality.	3 (1.3)	6 (2.5)	10 (4.2)	107 (44.6)	114 (47.5)
Parental engagement in school management motivates teachers to maintain higher standards of instructional preparation.	2 (0.8)	7 (2.9)	12 (5.0)	110 (45.8)	109 (45.4)
Alumni and private sector contributions to school resources directly improve the teaching and learning environment.	3 (1.3)	8 (3.3)	9 (3.8)	108 (45.0)	112 (46.7)
Civil society oversight of school governance strengthens teacher	4 (1.7)	9 (3.8)	11 (4.6)	106 (44.2)	110 (45.8)

compliance with professional duties and ethical standards.					
Stakeholders' involvement in school management collectively serves as a panacea for teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance.	2 (0.8)	5 (2.1)	8 (3.3)	109 (45.4)	116 (48.3)

Source: Field Data, (2026)

The findings in Table 1 demonstrate a strong consensus among respondents on the positive influence of stakeholders' involvement on teachers' effectiveness. Specifically, 92.1% of respondents agreed or strongly agreed that community participation in school governance enhances teachers' professional accountability and lesson delivery quality, while 93.7% agreed or strongly agreed that stakeholders' involvement collectively serves as a panacea for teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance. The uniformity of agreement across all items with disagreement rates below 5% for every item strongly affirms the study's central thesis that stakeholder involvement is a panacea for teachers' effectiveness in Cross River State secondary schools.

A teacher who participated in the study reflected:

"When parents and community members are actively involved in our school management, I feel a sense of professional responsibility that goes beyond what any supervisor can impose. Knowing that the community is watching, supporting, and contributing to what we do in the classroom makes me more committed to preparing my lessons thoroughly, coming to school on time, and ensuring that my students understand what I teach them. Their involvement gives me both the resources I need to teach well and the motivation to justify the trust they place in us as teachers. (Teacher, 2026)"

These findings are consistent with those of Epstein (2018) in the USA, who documented that institutionalised stakeholder involvement significantly enhances teacher morale and instructional effectiveness, and with Nwankwo (2020) in Anambra State, Nigeria, who found a significant positive correlation between PTA engagement and teachers' professional performance. The evidence from Akyeampong (2020) in Ghana further reinforces these findings by demonstrating that community oversight mechanisms reduce teacher absenteeism and improve lesson completion rates in resource-constrained public secondary schools. The implication of these findings for Cross River State is that a shift from tokenistic to genuine stakeholder involvement in school management can serve as a cost-effective and community-rooted strategy for significantly improving teachers' effectiveness in the state's secondary schools.

The finding that alumni and private sector contributions directly improve the teaching and learning environment (91.7% agreement) is particularly noteworthy. In the context of Cross River State, where many secondary schools continue to lack basic instructional infrastructure, the mobilisation of alumni and private sector resources through structured stakeholder involvement frameworks

can partially compensate for the inadequacies of government funding. A principal interviewed for the study noted:

"Our school alumni association provided us with a fully equipped science laboratory last year. Before that, our teachers were teaching practical science without any equipment, which was both demoralising for them and damaging to student learning. Since the laboratory was established, our science teachers have become noticeably more enthusiastic, more confident, and more effective because they can now teach the way they were trained to teach. That is the power of stakeholder involvement it gives teachers the tools they need to be truly effective. (Principal, 2026)"

This qualitative evidence vividly illustrates the material dimension of stakeholders' effectiveness function and supports the quantitative findings in Table 1. It also resonates with the findings of Mestry (2017) in South Africa, who documented that schools with active governing bodies were significantly better resourced and consequently achieved higher levels of teacher effectiveness.

Stakeholders' Involvement and Cooperative Governance

Table 3 presents respondents' perceptions of the influence of stakeholders' involvement on cooperative governance in secondary schools in Cross River State.

Table 3: Respondents' Responses on Stakeholders' Involvement and Cooperative Governance in Secondary Schools in Cross River State (N = 240)

Items	Response Options F (%)				
	SD	D	N	A	SA
Structured stakeholder participation in school governance decisions promotes transparency and reduces institutional conflicts.	2 (0.8)	6 (2.5)	9 (3.8)	108 (45.0)	115 (47.9)
Regular stakeholder engagement creates a shared sense of ownership and responsibility for school outcomes among teachers and community members.	3 (1.3)	7 (2.9)	10 (4.2)	111 (46.3)	109 (45.4)
Parental and community involvement in school budget management reduces financial mismanagement and improves resource accountability.	3 (1.3)	8 (3.3)	11 (4.6)	107 (44.6)	111 (46.3)

Stakeholder-driven school development planning ensures that institutional priorities reflect the needs of the community and the teaching staff.	2 (0.8)	6 (2.5)	12 (5.0)	112 (46.7)	108 (45.0)
Community oversight of teacher performance through stakeholder forums contributes to a culture of cooperative governance in secondary schools.	3 (1.3)	7 (2.9)	10 (4.2)	110 (45.8)	110 (45.8)

Source: Field Data, (2026)

The findings in Table 2 reveal a remarkably high level of agreement among respondents on the positive relationship between stakeholders' involvement and cooperative governance. Notably, 93.8% of respondents agreed or strongly agreed that structured stakeholder participation promotes transparency and reduces institutional conflicts, while 91.6% agreed or strongly agreed that regular stakeholder engagement creates a shared sense of ownership and responsibility for school outcomes. These findings affirm that stakeholders' involvement is perceived as a foundational element of cooperative governance in Cross River State secondary schools, capable of transforming the governance culture from a closed administrative system to an open, participatory, and accountable institutional arrangement.

The finding that parental and community involvement in school budget management reduces financial mismanagement (90.9% agreement) addresses one of the most persistent governance challenges in Nigerian secondary schools. A PTA representative who participated in the study observed:

"In our school, we introduced a system where three PTA executives are members of the school's financial committee and all expenditures above a certain amount must be jointly approved. Since we implemented this arrangement two years ago, there has been no case of fund misappropriation, and teachers have noticed that the school is now purchasing the materials they request for classroom use because the management knows we are watching. When stakeholders are genuinely involved in financial governance, accountability improves for everyone. (PTA Representative, 2026)"

This qualitative insight powerfully illustrates the accountability function of stakeholder involvement and corroborates the quantitative findings in Table 2. It is consistent with the evidence from Ssekamwa and Lugumba (2020) in Uganda, who documented that schools with community financial oversight committees demonstrated more transparent financial management and higher levels of teacher job satisfaction. The findings also align with Okoth (2021) in Kenya, who found that schools with actively engaged Boards of Management reported significantly stronger governance outcomes compared to schools with passive governance structures.

The finding that community oversight of teacher performance through stakeholder forums contributes to cooperative governance (91.6% agreement) is particularly significant for Cross River State, where teacher absenteeism and professional laxity have been documented as persistent challenges (Eteng & Ogbaji, 2022). A community leader who participated in the study articulated this dimension:

"In our community, we now hold quarterly meetings with the school management where we present our observations about teacher attendance, school cleanliness, and the activities of students outside school hours. These meetings are not meant to embarrass anyone but to show that the community is a partner in education, not just a spectator. Since we began doing this, we have seen positive changes in teacher behaviour and school discipline because both teachers and management know that the community is engaged and will speak up when things are not going well. (Community Leader, 2026)"

These findings collectively affirm the theoretical frameworks underpinning this study. Freeman's Stakeholder Theory is validated by the evidence that the systematic engagement of diverse stakeholders in school management produces superior governance outcomes, including transparency, accountability, and institutional conflict reduction. Dewey's Participatory Democracy Theory and Habermas's communicative action framework are equally supported by the finding that open, deliberative stakeholder participation generates shared ownership, democratic governance culture, and collective commitment to educational goals in Cross River State secondary schools. Taken together, the findings from Tables 1 and 2, supported by rich qualitative evidence, provide compelling empirical support for the conclusion that stakeholders' involvement in the management of secondary schools is indeed a panacea for teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance in Cross River State, Nigeria.

Limitations of the Study

Several limitations should be considered when interpreting the findings of this study. First, the study adopted a cross-sectional design, which limits the ability to establish causal relationships among the variables. While significant correlations were observed, it cannot be concluded that stakeholders' involvement directly causes improvements in teachers' effectiveness or cooperative governance.

Second, the study was conducted exclusively in Cross River State. Consequently, the findings may not be fully generalisable to other states in Nigeria or to different educational contexts with varying governance structures and stakeholder dynamics.

Third, the response pattern across questionnaire items showed consistently high levels of agreement, with most items receiving agreement rates above 90 percent. Although this may reflect genuinely positive perceptions of stakeholder involvement, it also raises the possibility of acquiescence bias or social desirability bias among respondents. Future studies should incorporate additional measures, such as observational methods, document analysis, and longitudinal designs, to validate self-reported responses and minimise potential response bias.

Finally, the study relied substantially on respondents' perceptions rather than objective measures of teacher effectiveness and governance performance. Future research should consider incorporating performance indicators and administrative records to provide a more comprehensive assessment of the relationships examined.

Conclusion

This study examined stakeholders' involvement in the management of secondary schools and its relationship with teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance in Cross River State, Nigeria. The findings suggest that respondents generally perceive stakeholder participation—including community involvement, parental engagement, alumni and private-sector contributions, and civil society oversight as being positively associated with teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance in secondary schools. Both the quantitative and qualitative evidence indicate that schools characterised by higher levels of stakeholder involvement tend to report stronger teacher accountability, improved instructional support, greater transparency in resource management, and more participatory governance practices.

The study further provides support for the propositions of Freeman's Stakeholder Theory and Dewey's Participatory Democracy Theory, which emphasise the value of inclusive participation in organisational governance and decision-making processes. Evidence from Cross River State indicates that structured stakeholder engagement is associated with positive perceptions of school effectiveness and governance quality. However, given the cross-sectional nature of the study, these findings should be interpreted as demonstrating relationships rather than causal effects.

Overall, the study contributes to the growing body of evidence suggesting that meaningful stakeholder involvement may play an important role in promoting effective school management and cooperative governance. The findings have implications for educational policy and practice by highlighting the potential value of strengthening stakeholder participation mechanisms within secondary schools. Future studies employing longitudinal, experimental, or multi-state designs are recommended to further examine the nature and direction of these relationships and to enhance the generalisability of the findings.

Recommendations

Based on the findings of this study, the following recommendations are offered:

1. The Cross River State Ministry of Education should enact a comprehensive Stakeholder Participation Policy for Secondary Schools that mandates structured, meaningful, and documented involvement of parents, community leaders, alumni associations, and civil society organisations in school governance processes, including annual school development planning, budget approval, teacher performance monitoring, and school evaluation activities.
2. The State Secondary Education Board (SSEB) should establish School-Based Management Committees (SBMCs) in all public secondary schools in Cross River State, composed of representatives from all key stakeholder groups, and provide capacity building training to equip committee members with the governance skills, financial management knowledge, and

educational oversight competencies needed to contribute effectively to cooperative governance.

3. School principals should be trained in participatory leadership and stakeholder engagement strategies as a core component of the professional development programme of the SSEB, with particular emphasis on how to transform PTA meetings from fundraising events into genuine governance forums where parents, community members, and teachers collectively deliberate on school management challenges and solutions.
4. The federal and state governments should provide incentive frameworks for alumni associations and private sector organisations that make documented contributions to secondary school management, including resource provision, teacher professional development sponsorship, and infrastructure support, in order to deepen and sustain their involvement in school governance over the long term.
5. Future research should investigate the specific mechanisms through which different forms of stakeholder involvement produce outcomes in teachers' effectiveness and cooperative governance, with particular attention to the mediating roles of institutional trust, resource availability, and school leadership quality in the stakeholder-outcomes relationship in Cross River State secondary schools.

References

- Adeyemi, T. O. (2021). Community involvement in school management and teachers' job performance in secondary schools in Ondo State, Nigeria. *American Journal of Social and Management Sciences*, 12(2), 34–47.
- Akyeampong, K. (2020). Community participation in school management and teacher accountability in rural Ghana. *International Journal of Educational Development*, 78, Article 102115. [or 102–115 depending on the journal's layout]
- Ategwe, P. O., Fanan, A. G., Ogbuli, J. U., & Jenny, M. (2023). Management of secondary school and teachers job satisfaction for sustainable development in Calabar Education Zone, Cross River State, Nigeria. *Nigerian Journal of Education in Developing Areas*, 31(3), 273–284.
- Bassey, U., & Okon, I. (2022). Stakeholder participation and secondary school governance in Cross River State: An assessment of current practices and emerging challenges. *Journal of Educational Policy and Entrepreneurial Research*, 9(1), 58–74.
- Creswell, J. W., & Plano Clark, V. L. (2018). *Designing and conducting mixed methods research* (3rd ed.). SAGE Publications.
- Cross River State Ministry of Education. (2024). *Annual report on secondary education in Cross River State*. Ministry of Education.
- Dewey, J. (1916). *Democracy and education: An introduction to the philosophy of education*. Macmillan.
- Epstein, J. L. (2018). *School, family, and community partnerships: Preparing educators and improving schools* (2nd ed.). Westview Press.

- Eteng, O. A., & Ogbaji, E. I. (2022). Teacher absenteeism and governance accountability in public secondary schools in Cross River State. *Nigerian Journal of Educational Administration*, 14(1), 77–92.
- Freeman, R. E. (1984). *Strategic management: A stakeholder approach*. Pitman Publishing.
- Fullan, M. (2020). *Leading in a culture of change* (2nd ed.). Jossey-Bass.
- Habermas, J. (1984). *The theory of communicative action: Vol. 1. Reason and the rationalisation of society* (T. McCarthy, Trans.). Beacon Press.
- Mestry, R. (2017). Empowering principals to lead and manage public schools effectively in the 21st century. *South African Journal of Education*, 37(1), 1–11.
- Ncube, A. C., & Jerie, S. (2021). Cooperative governance in school management: A framework for developing countries. *International Journal of Educational Management*, 35(4), 890–905.
- Ndem, B. E., Delight, O. J., Ategwu, P. O., & Ken-Aklah, F. O. (2023). Teachers capacity building and teaching effectiveness for global competitiveness in secondary schools in Obudu Local Government Area, Cross River State. *Ignatius Ajuru University Journal of Educational Management*, 3(1), 404–413.
- Nwankwo, O. C. (2020). Parent-teacher association engagement and teachers' job performance in secondary schools in Anambra State, Nigeria. *Journal of Educational Management and Supervision*, 6(2), 45–61.
- Obasi, C., & Nwosu, K. (2022). Organisational climate and teachers' effectiveness in Nigerian secondary schools. *African Journal of Educational Research*, 10(3), 112–128.
- Oduya, P. O., & Odey, F. E. (2023). Democratic governance and school management reforms in Nigeria: Challenges and prospects. *Journal of Educational Policy and Entrepreneurial Research*, 10(2), 33–49.
- Okoth, T. A. (2021). Board of management involvement and teacher professional performance in Kenyan public secondary schools. *East African Journal of Education Studies*, 4(1), 78–93.
- Sahlberg, P. (2021). *Finnish lessons 3.0: What can the world learn from educational change in Finland?* (3rd ed.). Teachers College Press.
- Ssekamwa, J. C., & Lugumba, S. M. E. (2020). Community participation and cooperative governance in Ugandan government secondary schools. *African Educational Research Journal*, 8(4), 210–225.
- Stronge, J. H. (2018). *Qualities of effective teachers* (3rd ed.). ASCD.
- UNESCO. (2022). *Stakeholder participation in school governance: Evidence and policy implications*. United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization.